

In Shibu Natesan's watercolour work 'A Day in the Life of a Construction Worker', we see the subject sitting quietly by himself at a construction site, even as the criss-crossing bamboo all around acts as a natural 'frame'. The framework has contained the worker entirely—he cannot escape these punishing terms his life is defined by, and yet at the same time, there is an undeniable peace and stillness in this moment. It's a simple yet powerful demonstration of the softness and grace associated with watercolours. The painting is part of the 59-year-old artist's ongoing solo exhibition *Mirror Man, Mirror Me* at Delhi's Art Alive Gallery—on till November 20—which brings together an array of watercolour paintings he has created from 2014-2025, alongside a small number of oil paintings as well. From the villages of Kerala to the markets of Uzbekistan to the hilly vistas of Uttarakhand, Natesan's watercolours are masterful depictions of the interplay between light and shadow, between documentation and storytelling.

"I love travelling and I love painting while travelling," says Natesan during an interview. "I go all across the country by myself, and even outside of the country. Painters who like to work on the move cannot carry so much equipment with them at all times. So, they prefer watercolours because they're quite portable. And personally, I have always loved watercolours, because of the ease with which you can capture natural light, and also because of how warm the colours are."

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A number of paintings in *Mirror Man, Mirror Me* capture a moment of performance, or an aspect of performativity in what is otherwise a 'regular' interaction. For example, a number of his oil-on-panel paintings use dolls and figurines as subjects, like 'Still Life' (20 x 16 inches) or 'Ladies Watch' (5.25 x 10 inches). According to Natesan, they carry the "essence of life" within their stillness, within their frozen-in-performance state. You can easily notice this aspect within some of the human-subject paintings as well, like 'Sales Girl' (72 x 60 inches, oil) and 'Beach Shop' (48 x 60 inches). But the peak of this phenomenon is 'Ophelia (After Millais)' (24 x 18 inches, watercolour), Natesan's homage to 'Ophelia', an 1851 oil painting by John Everett Millais, who drew the *Hamlet* character Ophelia as she drowns in a rather picturesque stream, surrounded by flowers and greenery. It is a distinctly cinematic framing and, indeed, down the years, a number of acclaimed filmmakers like Andrei Tarkovsky and Lars von Trier have made visual allusions to this image in their work.

"I love that painting, 'Ophelia'," says Natesan. "It's part of Tate's collection in London and whenever I am in London, I always make time to go and see it. The artist John Everett Millais was one of the founders of the 'pre-Raphaelite' group of artists. Because it's a Shakespeare character being depicted here, it's obviously a very dramatic bit of storytelling. I wanted to highlight that feeling, but in an Indian setting. The landscape that you see in my painting is from Uttarakhand."

The exhibition also includes a series of self-portraits Natesan has created over the past decade, and it's fascinating to see how an artist comes to terms with his own ageing...especially an artist like Natesan, whose artistic gaze is marked by instant warmth and compassion, as opposed to a rigorous, cinema verité-like dedication to accuracy and 'the truth'. According to the artist, his finished products look like they took